60-70% Reduction in answered spam calls after Airtel's spam solution launch

36-60 Age group that was the most targeted on Airtel network, receiving 48% of spam calls

Sources: Airtel, TRAI, DoT

Union communications minister Jyotiraditya Scindia tells INDIA TODAY (*see interview*). While government systems work to catch up, users like Dr O.P. Choudhury, a neurologist at Apollo Hospital in Delhi, remain overwhelmed. "I may be able to protect myself from scammers posing as police or government officials, but I have no shield against spams. They flood my message box and call anytime of the day," he says. "A doctor's phone is for important communication. I cannot ignore calls or message notifications."

Cognizant of such travails, telcos themselves have taken a lead. Airtel, for instance, is now harnessing its proprietary AI technology to proactively screen spam calls and messages. Processing an astounding 1 trillion records daily, the system analyses patterns like call frequency and duration to identify potential spam. The result? Over 100 million spam calls and 3 million spam messages are blocked every day. "Spam has become a menace for customers. We have spent the past 12 months solving this comprehensively," says Gopal Vittal, MD & CEO, Bharti Airtel.

Vodafone Idea (Vi), too, has its own AI-powered spam detection system. Analysing incoming SMSes in real time, it tags dubious messages as 'Suspected Spam' to alert users. Reliance Jio has recently adopted a similar technology. However, the effectiveness of these systems remains less evident than their providers suggest. "If there is improvement, it's not nearly enough. The burden is still on the user to block or report spam," says Annie George, a freelance content creator in Bengaluru. Unfortunately, a foolproof system may not be achievable anytime soon. "I'm sure the people who create these kinds of fraud and calls know how to navigate through the system," Bawa says. "I don't think there is a 100 per cent solution ever."

International call spoofing prevention
DoT launched the International Incoming Spoofed Calls Prevention System in August 2024 to intercept and block fraudulent international calls

Fixing accountability
Around 14,000 principal entities like banks and insurance companies have declared over 21,000 chains of telemarketers, ensuring greater accountability for their commercial communications

Expansion of joint committee of regulators
It now includes Insurance Regulatory & Development Authority, Pension Fund Regulatory & Development Authority and Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology alongside TRAI, RBI and Sebi

Consumer awareness initiatives
Platforms like the Sanchar Saathi portal and TRAI's DND app have been promoted to help users report spam and manage their communication preferences

India, with over a billion mobile phone users, is one of the world's most spam-hit countries. Complaints about pesky calls and messages have surged

The TRAI Crackdown

TRAI's Telecom Commercial Communication Customer Preference Regulation, 2018 set the rules for spam control, using blockchain-based Distributed Ledger Technology (DLT). Think of it as a database in multiple locations but shared by all telecom operators to check and verify. India became the first country worldwide to use such a system to block spam. All nine main operators need to record each registered sender, their headers and templates on the DLT platform. The system divides commercial communications into eight types, including finance, health, real estate and others. Consumers may choose not to receive certain categories.

However, it doesn't inspire much confidence in users. Over 240 million of them—about 20 per cent of subscribers—have registered to block or control spam by citing their preferences. TRAI is preparing to overhaul its 2018 regulations. Proposed changes include differential tariffs for promotional messages, stricter punishments for violators and better traceability for spam calls. Meanwhile, platforms like WhatsApp are being enlisted, with discussions underway to regulate spam on over-the-top (OTT) services.

Who's On the Line?

Annu Saroj, a 23-year-old call centre executive from Balia, Uttar Pradesh, recently quit her job because "she couldn't cope with the pressure". Operating out of a two-room office in Chandigarh, her company made cold calls all day, offering to find suitable jobs for people in exchange for Rs 2,000 and a cut of their first month's salary. "As a junior, I was expected to make at least 40 calls in an eight-hour shift, all breaks included," she says. Annu had some 15 colleagues, who were given lists of mobile numbers sourced from various portals. "If we made a sale, there would be a commission over and above the monthly salary of Rs 14,000." She quit when the target was increased to clock 60 calls at first and then 75.

Since August last year, the DoT, TRAI, telcos and virtually the entire